

The Behavioral Perspective: Understanding Human Nature Through Mental Processes

Brent Limbo

Department of Psychology, Irvine Valley College

PSY 101: Introduction to Psychology

Professor El-Mouazzen

5/11/2026

Introduction

In this world, everyone is different, specifically in the way we each act, behave, or feel. This makes us question why everyone is this way. Psychology answers this, as it is the study of the human mind, understanding different mental processes and behaviors. There are different Psychological Perspectives: Biological, Psychodynamic, Behavioral, Cognitive, Humanistic, and Sociocultural. These perspectives show a comprehensive understanding of the processes of the human mind. Since these perspectives each have their own approach, the human mind is shaped by their behavior through conditioning, learning, and observation. Therefore, the behavioral perspective is the best approach because human behavior is influenced by the environment and interactions we can see, feel, and experience.

Perspective

In 1913, John B. Watson published his paper, “Psychology as the Behaviorist's View It”, establishing the behavioral perspective. The behavioral perspective, or behaviorism, suggests that behavior is shaped through conditioning, in which a human is conditioned to act a certain way. (The Decision Lab, 2022) Because of this, humans can learn certain actions with the right conditions. Through the stimulus, our behaviors are our response to the interaction directed at us.

Often, this perspective is misunderstood, as others assume that people are naturally born to behave a certain way. This is also known as being born on a blank slate, as our identity is developed by our experiences over time, which include our skills and personality. (Mike, 2012) With this assumption, it argues that our brains are not structured to produce our behaviors. Additionally, it is assumed that this perspective relies on a stimulus-response. A certain stimulus can cause every behavior and represent methodological behaviorism. (Mike, 2012) However,

these assumptions do not solely explain the behavioral perspective; there are more factors of human behavior, such as mental processes and biological influences.

There are essential key concepts to the behavioral perspective, including for each aspect of human behavior. These concepts are classical conditioning, operant conditioning, and reinforcement. All of them explain the main mechanisms of behavior through the lens of learning, consequence, and observational learning.

First, classical conditioning is where our conditioned responses are associated with a specific stimulus. This is our ability to learn, which includes gaining knowledge, behavior, or ideas. (Rehman et al., 2024) Pavlov's experiment demonstrated that dogs reacted under certain conditions, linking them to their stimuli. For example, the dogs ate their food conditionally, while at other times they were trained that the bell indicated it was time to eat. Dogs are similar to humans in a way that our minds associate different ideas with different things.

Next, operant conditioning is that consequences determine our behavior. B. F. Skinner found that an organism learns to associate their behavior with a consequence. (McLeod, 2025) In this theory, behavior is divided into two effects: satisfying and discomforting. The Satisfying effect is when behavior is correlated with repeated pleasant consequences, while the Discomforting effect is when behavior is correlated with unrepeated unpleasant consequences. These are positive and negative reinforcement to the learning aspect of the human mind. For example, when studying, you get a good grade, but if you don't study, you fail.

Lastly, observational learning is when we learn by watching others. As we watch others do something, we acquire information in our minds on how to replicate it. It is found that humans are like social animals when it comes to observational learning. (Nickerson, 2024) Parrots are a great example of this because they imitate sounds and behaviors in their

surroundings. Furthermore, Bandura experimented with children, with one control group watching an adult punching and kicking the Bobo Doll, while the other group watched and played with it nicely. Their observations are reflected in their behavior once they get hold of the Bobo Doll.

Thus, these concepts explain the behavioral perspective because these theories agree that behavior is developed through learning. This learning can be in various ways, such as being conditioned by a certain stimulus, understanding right or wrong actions, and observing others. At the end, they all reflect on how we behave, act, and think.

Compare to Other Perspectives

The behavior perspective assumes that behaviorism relies on ideas, such as classical conditioning, operant conditioning, and observational learning, but there are other perspectives that explain behavior differently. Another perspective, biological, explains human behavior differently because it focuses on the physical foundations of the body. Genetics is considered the main foundation, since they act as a biological blueprint through neurotransmitter receptors and brain structure. The cognitive perspective looks at the internal mental processes deeply, involving perception, memory, thinking, and language. Both perspectives explain their approaches through human mechanics, but the behavioral perspective explains behavior better because it is based on learning that is observable and measurable.

Personal Agreement

Personally, I agree with the behavioral perspective because, from my viewpoint, I see many aspects in our environment that can shape a person's identity. An environment, in general, is subjective, as it can be anything, like the interactions between people or the place you're in, such as school, home, work, or on vacation. All of these factors make a person who they are. For

instance, my friends are a direct influence on my identity because I am surrounded by them all the time in school. This means their actions can influence me or others. Similarly, you are a blank canvas, and the paint is the environment. The final painting symbolizes your identity after experiencing the environment, whether through interaction, learning, conditioning, or observing.

Conclusion

To conclude, the behavior perspective explains human behavior as each person is shaped through conditioning, learning, and observation. Each human performs each of these factors every day, where they eventually become part of our identity. It also includes brain structure as stimuli are involved. Furthermore, they are backed up by theories developed by psychologists in experiments, such as Bandura's, where children learn new things based on what they see in front of them. This perspective shows that the environment we surround ourselves with determines behavior, such as emotions, actions, or morals, as is evident in the experiments conducted.

References

- The Decision Lab. (2022). *Behavioral Perspective*. The Decision Lab. Retrieved 5 10, 2026, from <https://thedecisionlab.com/reference-guide/philosophy/behavioral-perspective>
- McLeod, S. (2025, October 17). *Operant Conditioning In Psychology: B.F. Skinner Theory*. Simply Psychology. Retrieved May 10, 2026, from <https://www.simplypsychology.org/operant-conditioning.html>
- Mike. (2012). *The Last Behaviorist*. blogger. Retrieved 10 5, 2026, from <https://thelastbehaviorist.blogspot.com/2012/11/misunderstanding-behaviorism.html>
- Nickerson, C. (2024, February 2). *Observational Learning In Psychology*. Simply Psychology. Retrieved May 11, 2026, from <https://www.simplypsychology.org/what-is-observational-learning.html>
- Rehman, I., Mahabadi, N., & Rehman, C. (2024, September 5). *Classical Conditioning*. National Library of Medicine. Retrieved 5 10, 2026, from <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK470326/>